

child to age 18. That's \$1,070 a month per child. That includes almost everything—food, clothes, medical and dental costs, school, extracurriculars, transportation costs, even braces.

Now that you've got the numbers staring you in the face, there's really no excuse for poor decisions. For your future children's sake, if not your own, take a calm, rational look at your finances and ask yourself: Can we afford it? Here's where the worksheets I had you complete earlier come back into play. The number of kids you have *must be tied to your annual surplus*. Remember, that's your 90-Day Number times four. To make it easy, I've provided a chart below.

THE COST OF KIDS

	ANNUAL SURPLUS NEEDED PER YEAR
1 Child	\$12,825
2 Children	\$25,650
3 Children	\$38,475
4 Children	\$51,300
5 Children	\$64,125

Keep in mind that these numbers do *not* include university tuition. If you want to send your child to university, you're looking at anywhere from \$20,000 to \$64,000 for a four-year degree. Thanks to inflation, that figure will go up significantly over the next 18 years, so if your wee one's still in swaddling clothes, expect to dole out anywhere between \$64,000 and \$137,000 for their university pedigree. If you make an annual contribution of \$2,000, your child's RESP will grow to \$71,166 in 18 years (based on a return of 5 percent per year and reinvestment of dividends).

You may think your children are going to take care of you in your old age, and this is a justification many people offer for having children. But many kids are too busy living their own lives (hence the surge of retirement homes and long-term care facilities) and